eSports in Korea

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Sports

League of Legends fan? Korea championship finals to take place in Hong Kong

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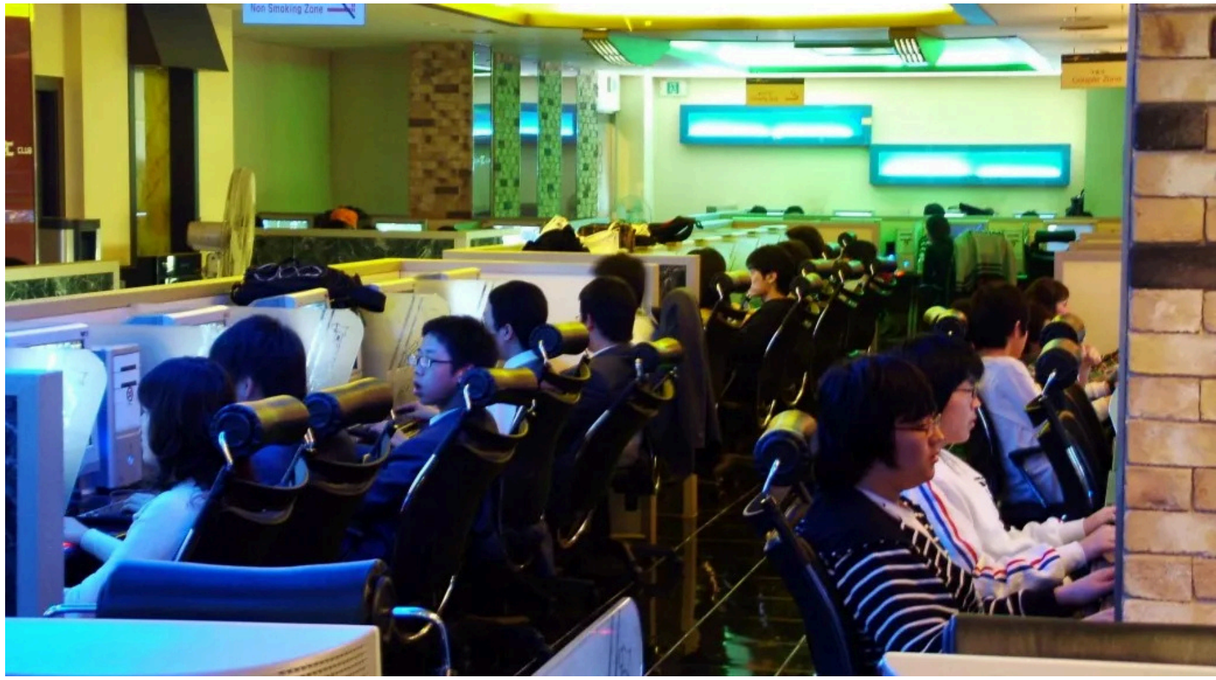
Trophy for the 2025 League of Legends Champions Korea Cup / Courtesy of LCK

What is eSports?

- Electronic Sports
- Competitive video-game-based tournaments in the forms of multiplayer or individual gaming
    - League of Legends (LOL)
    - PUBG
    - Dota2
    - VALORANT

- First Esports Competition was held in 1972 in California, USA
- Was first introduced in South Korea in the late 1990s
    - rise in number of PC Bangs/ Internet Cafes



Current Situation

- eSports is identified as a cultural industry in Korea
- Large Korean government support for the development of eSports
  - 380.226 Billion Korean Won invested in eSports from 2008-2012
  - 230 Billion Won invested in 2014
  - 77.7 Billion Won invested in 2024
- In 2025, there are more than 60 eSports tournaments in Korea
- eSports continues to be one of the major influencing factors in Korea's economic development, behind K-POP and K-Dramas

Government Laws

Act on Promotion of E-Sports (2012)

- It is mentioned that all states and local governments MUST implement policies to promote eSports
- Focuses on boosting competitiveness and popularity

Comprehensive Amendment Bill to the Act on Promotion of Game Culture and Industry (2025)

- Mentions the process of designating training institutions for gaming industry, and covers their expenses
- Focuses on talent and investment

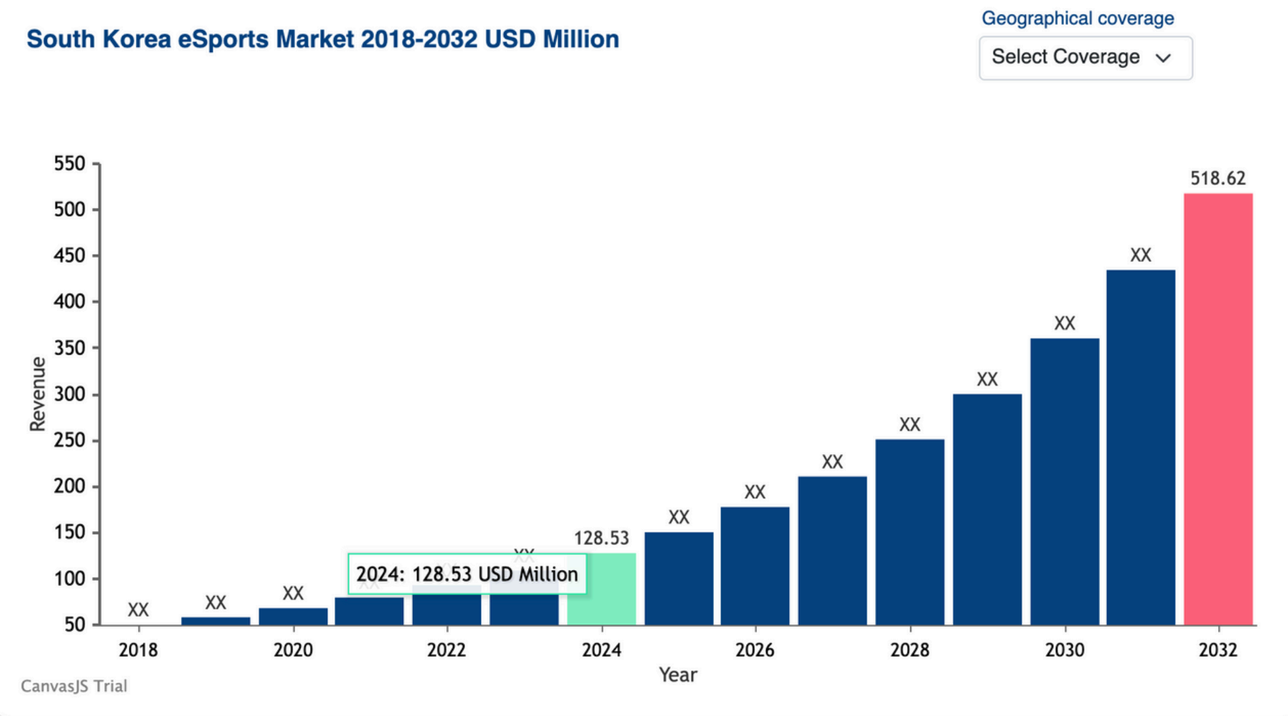
Large Korean government support!

Seoul e-Stadium

Busan Esports Arena

A possible Career Path?

- **A Structured employment engine**
  - Top-tiered players can earn up to $100,000 USD
  - Pro players, coaches, trainers, sport psychologists, nutritionists
- **There are many Esports Academies in Korea**
  - Gen. G Global Academy (GGA)
  - Nongshim Esports Academy
  - DRX
- **Led to the emerge of 80,000 new job opportunities**
  - Commentators, game developers, event planners etc.



Projected eSports market value in 2032: **$518.62 Million USD**

	South Korea	Hong Kong
Stage of development	**Matured**: One of the largest markets in the world	**Initialization stage**: Growing Market
Scale of eSports	**Large** >60 eSports Tournaments in Korea in 2025 Overseas growth	**Small** Only 5 eSports Tournaments in Hong Kong in 2025 Local growth
Government Support	**Large, continuous support** Sufficient space for training of eSports, Large Scale in promotion	**Relatively Small** HKSAR government allocated HK$100 million to eSports in 2018-2019, Insufficient Space for training of eSports Small scale in promotion
Role of eSports in economic growth	One of the **main** economic incomes in the cultural sector	A **growing** source of income in the cultural sector
Level of public Acceptance of Esports	**High level of acceptance:** People view eSports as a legitimate, viable career path, and a professional sport with government recognition	**Low level of acceptance:** People don't view eSports as a (feasible) career path, but the thoughts are changing with the growing market

Thank You!